

Stage 8

A big theatre console's mix bus as an eight-stem summing mixer, with VCA groups.



Overview

Stage 8 sums eight stereo stems through the mix bus of a big British theatre console, in the spirit of the consoles famous for their clarity in the West End and on Broadway. Each stem has a level, a pan, a VCA assign, solo and mute; two VCA group masters ride whole groups of stems with one knob.

Two console characters are on board. VINTAGE is the earlier, transformer-coupled desk: the lows thicken and saturate gently as the level rises, there is a soft lift in the presence region, a silky top that rolls off just above the audio band, a whisper of crosstalk and noise, and a gentle squeeze when driven. MODERN is the later transformerless desk: flat, wide, true stereo, with enormous headroom.

DRIVE sets the level into the summing amplifiers. It is level-matched, so it changes the colour, not the volume.

Reach for it for

- Summing stems or groups through one console-style bus
- Riding several stems together with a VCA master
- Adding gentle transformer weight and a silky top to a mix (VINTAGE)
- Clean, wide summing with solo and mute in one place (MODERN)
- Theatre-style mixing: grouping a band, vocals and effects for quick balancing

Setting up the routing in REAPER

1. Create a bus track and put Stage 8 on it. Open the track's ROUTE window and set Track channels to 16.
2. On each stem track, add a send to the bus track and pick its destination channel pair in the send's audio routing: stem 1 on 1/2, stem 2 on 3/4, stem 3 on 5/6, and so on up to stem 8 on 15/16. The pair is printed under each strip's name.
3. Turn off the master send on every stem track, so the stems are heard only through Stage 8.
4. Stem 1 also receives whatever plays on the bus track itself (channels 1/2), so keep the bus track empty or use it as stem 1.
5. The mix leaves on channels 1/2, so leave the bus track's master send on. The green light on each strip lights when signal arrives and the stem is being heard.

Controls

Drag a knob up or down to turn it, or double-click to reset it.

The header

PRESETS	Opens the list of factory presets (clicking the display does the same). A preset sets only MODE and DRIVE; the stems and VCAs are left as they are. The last entry resets everything to the defaults.
Left / right arrows	Step to the previous or next preset.
S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

Stems 1 to 8

Name	Click the name at the top of the strip and type (e.g. Drums), up to 16 characters. Enter keeps it, Escape cancels, and an
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	empty name goes back to the number. The names are saved with the project.
Signal light	Glows green when audio arrives on the stem and it is being heard.
PAN	A balance control, L100 to R100: in the centre both sides play at full level; turning it fades the opposite side down.
LEVEL	The stem's level, from OFF (-60 dB) to +10 dB; 0 dB by default.
VCA	Click to step the stem's VCA assign: none (VCA -), VCA A (orange light) or VCA B (blue light). An assigned stem follows that VCA master's level and mute.
SOLO	Solo in place; several stems can be soloed at once. While anything is soloed, only the soloed stems are heard.
MUTE	Silences the stem. A muted stem stays muted even when soloed.

VCA A and VCA B

LEVEL	The group master, OFF (-60 dB) to +10 dB. It rides every stem assigned to it, on top of their own levels.
MUTE	Mutes every stem assigned to that VCA.

MASTER

VINTAGE / MODERN	Picks the console. VINTAGE: transformer-coupled, with low-end thickening, presence lift, a silky top, a whisper of crosstalk and noise, and a gentle squeeze when driven. MODERN: transformerless - flat and clean, and only extreme levels are softly limited. The caption under the controls reads TRANSFORMER-COUPLED or TRANSFORMERLESS.
DRIVE	The level into the summing amps, -6 to +12 dB. It is level-matched: more DRIVE gives more colour in VINTAGE, not

	more volume.
MASTER	The final mix level, from OFF (-60 dB) to +10 dB.
L / R meters	Two 12-light meters showing the mix output; 0 on the meter is -18 dBFS.

Presets

Vintage	The transformer-coupled console, DRIVE at 0 dB.
Vintage, driven	The vintage console with 6 dB of drive.
Vintage, pushed hard	The vintage console with 10 dB of drive, for a thicker, squeezed bus.
Modern	The transformerless console, DRIVE at 0 dB.
Modern, driven	The modern console with 6 dB of drive.
Reset all to defaults	Every control back to its starting value, including stem levels, pans, VCA assigns, solos, mutes and the VCA masters.

Tips

- Assign the band to VCA A and the vocals to VCA B: then one knob each balances the whole show, as on a theatre desk.
- Because DRIVE is level-matched, you can sweep it and judge the colour without being fooled by loudness.
- Name the strips - the names are saved with the project, so the console makes sense when you come back to it.
- Try VINTAGE with DRIVE at +6 dB on a full mix, then switch to MODERN to hear how much of the weight and silk comes from the transformer stages.

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